Gopala Bhatta Gosvami

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One of the Six Gosvamis

Gopala Bhatta Gosvami is one of the six Gosvamis of Vrindavana, an eternal associate of Sri Krishna Chaitanya, who received His mercy while still a child, in the days of his boyhood play. He is also called more briefly Bhatta Gopala, Bhatta Gosvami and Bhatta-pada. At the beginning of the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami honours him among his six shiksha-gurus, his instructors:

"Sri Rupa and Sri Sanatana Gosvami, Sri Bhatta Raghunatha Gosvami, Sri Jiva Gosvami, Srila Gopala Bhatta Gosvami and Sri Dasa Raghunatha Gosvami. With reverence I bow millions of times at the lotus feet of these six instructors of mine." (CC, Adi 1.36–37)

And listing the branches of the Chaitanya tree, the Kaviraja says of him:

"The forty-sixth branch, Sri Gopala Bhatta Gosvami, is one of the very greatest. In the company of Sri Rupa and Sanatana Gosvami he discussed the essence of pure love for Krishna." (CC, Adi 10.105)

The six Gosvamis are Sanatana, Rupa, Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta, Raghunatha Bhatta and Jiva; Lokanatha and Bhugarbha were honoured as the seventh and eighth, and people sometimes speak of "nine Gosvamis", among them "the two Bhattas". Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, tracing the line of instruction (shiksha-parampara), leads it from Mahaprabhu to Svarupa Damodara, from him to Rupa and Sanatana, beside whom stand Raghunatha Dasa, Raghunatha Bhatta and Gopala Bhatta, and onward to Jiva and Krishnadasa Kaviraja.

Years of His Life

The biographies disagree about the year of his appearance. Bhaktivinoda Thakura, in the "Sajjana-toshani" (year 2, in the article "Determining the Years of the Six Gosvamis"), gives the same figures as the records collected by Pandita Vishvambharananda Deva Gosvami of Shripata Gopivallabhapura: Gopala Bhatta appeared in 1425 of the Shaka era (1503), lived thirty years at home and forty-five in Vraja, and departed in 1500 Shaka (1578), having spent seventy-five years on earth.[1] The day of his appearance, by our calendar, is the krishna-tritiya of the month of Madhava.[2]

Shrirangam

Gopala Bhatta was born in Shrirangam, in the family of the brahmana Venkata Bhatta; their house, it is said, stood in the village of Belgundi not far from the town.[3] Sri Ranga-kshetra lies on the Kaveri near Trichinopoly, about five kroshas (some ten miles) west of Kumbhakonam, in the district of Tanjore. Its presiding Deity is Sri Ranganatha, Vishnu, and His temple with its seven enclosures is the largest in India.

Three brothers had settled in Shrirangam from Mysore: Trimalla (Tirumalai), Venkata and the youngest, Prabodhananda.[4] All three were Shri Vaishnavas of Ramanuja's school, worshippers of Lakshmi-Narayana, and had formerly been acharyas of the Shri Sampradaya; Venkata belonged to its Vadagalai branch, while Prabodhananda was then a tridandi sannyasi. It is said that the brothers actually came from Andhra or Uttar Pradesh; the names Venkata and Tirumalai are not in use in Tamil Nadu, and the family probably settled in Shrirangam shortly before the Lord came — though perhaps it had lived there for a long time.

In 1433 Shaka (1511)[5] Mahaprabhu, visiting the holy places of the South, came on the ashadha shukla-ekadashi to Sri Ranga-kshetra on the bank of the Kaveri — the river of which the "Bhagavatam" (11.5.39–40) says that those who drink its water are purified in heart and attain pure bhakti for Vasudeva. The "Chaitanya-charitamrita" relates:

"In Papa-nashana He visited the temple of Vishnu and then went on to Sri Ranga-kshetra. He bathed in the river Kaveri and then visited the temple of Ranganatha. Offering many prayers to that Deity, He felt that His life had been filled with the highest meaning. In that temple He sang and danced so much in the rapture of divine love that everyone was amazed to see it. One of the Shri Vaishnavas, named Venkata Bhatta, invited Sri Chaitanya to his home with the deepest respect. Bringing the Lord home, he washed His feet and drank that water together with his household. Then, having fed Sri Chaitanya, Venkata Bhatta humbly addressed Him: 'Prabhu! Chaturmasya has already begun. Please be merciful to me and stay in my home for the whole of this rainy season. Mercifully deliver me by granting me the chance to hear Krishna-katha from Your lips.' So Sri Chaitanya stayed in that house for the four months of the rainy season, happily spending His days in discussing with Venkata Bhatta the various aspects of the spiritual rasas with Krishna." (CC, Madhya 9.79–86)

Papanashana, where the Lord saw Vishnu, lies four kroshas south-west of Kumbhakonam. According to one account, Venkata, recognizing in the Lord the marks of a mahapurusha, pushed through the crowd to Him and sang and danced with Him, and when the Lord came back to outer awareness he fell at His feet, and the Lord embraced him, saying, "Krishna! Krishna!" Venkata begged Him to stay, so that he might hear from Him about Krishna and at last climb out of the well of samsara. For four months the Lord lived in his house and in his company; every day He bathed in the Kaveri, saw Ranganatha, and sang and danced before Him. Hundreds of thousands came to see Him; they chanted the name of Krishna and attained bhakti. Every day a different brahmana Vaishnava invited Him to a meal, and some never got their turn.

In Venkata's house the Lord held playful talks with His host about Lakshmi-Narayana and Radha-Govinda. Why, He asked, does chaste Lakshmi, who lives on her Husband's breast, seek the company of the cowherd boy Krishna? Venkata replied that Krishna and Narayana are one svarupa, but Krishna is higher in rasa. Here sounds the verse of the "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu" that the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" also quotes:

"According to the conclusions of enlightened souls there is no difference between the transcendental nature of Krishna and of Narayana, the Husband of Lakshmi. But there is one indisputable excellence that places Krishna above all other forms of God, Narayana included: only in the form of Krishna are all kinds of rasa, of spiritual relationship, revealed in their fullness." (CC, Madhya 9.117)

But why then, the Lord went on, was Lakshmi not admitted to the rasa dance, while the personified shrutis were? Uddhava in the "Bhagavatam" (10.47.60) testifies that not even Lakshmi on the Lord's breast received the mercy the gopis received, and the shrutis (10.87.23) attained it by following the gopis. There is no right to serve Krishna without following the people of Vraja and the gopis: whoever worships Him in one of the four moods of Vraja attains Krishna, the son of the king of Vraja. The shrutis entered the rasa dance by taking the bodies and mood of gopis, whereas Lakshmi sought Krishna in her own form, without following the natural love of the cowherd maidens. In God there is no division: the difference of the forms contemplated comes from the difference in the moods of the devotees. Krishna attracts all by His sweetness (CC, Madhya 9.127–131); He is the original Bhagavan (CC, Adi 2.88; "Bhagavatam" 1.3.28), possessed of four special qualities, and Radhika contains within Herself all the Lakshmis. Venkata understood that before him stood Krishna Himself and fell at His feet; the Lord embraced him and immersed him in the rasa of service to Krishna.[6]

From then on the whole family — Venkata, Prabodhananda, the boy Gopala and all the household — gave up the worship of Lakshmi-Narayana and surrendered to Radha-Krishna. Narahari Chakravarti says of the brothers:

“Trimalla, Venkata and Sri Prabodhananda — the treasure of the lives of these three brothers is Gaurachandra. Formerly they were worshippers of Lakshmi-Narayana; by the Lord's mercy they became intoxicated with the rasa of Radha and Krishna.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.83–84)

The Boy at the Lord's Feet

The Lord's very stay in Venkata's house, it is said, was for the sake of His mercy to Gopala and his family: the Lord knew that His eternal associate had appeared there. When Venkata's household drank the water that had washed the Lord's feet, the host's son, the boy Gopala, drank it too — and was filled with prema. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” remarks that the Lord's southern journey is described in detail in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”, but Gopala Bhatta's name is not revealed there — only Venkata's family is named; elsewhere, however, it is said that Gopala is Venkata's son. Having drunk the water from the Lord's feet, he could not grow calm, his body thrilled with gooseflesh, and, having found the Lord of his life in his own home, at his father's bidding he served Him with great joy.

The ancients composed a verse about him:

“I praise Sri Bhatta Gopala, the best of brahmanas, the son of Venkata, appointed to the service of Sri Chaitanya Prabhu in his own home.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.98)

The boy massaged the Lord's feet. When he first bowed to Him, the Lord took him on His lap and embraced him; He would call him and give him the remnants of His prasada, blessing him thereby to become a great acharya, and every day Gopala served Him personally. Venkata rejoiced to see his son's love for serving Gaura: he did not look on Gopala as a son born for his own pleasure, and always gave him to the service of Gaurachandra's feet.

Once, when Gopala was massaging His feet, the Lord said: “Serve your father and mother for a while, and then you will go to Vrindavana; there, with Rupa and Sanatana, you will find the highest bliss.” These words are recorded in the “Karnananda” (fifth niryasa) of Yadunandana Dasa, a disciple of Hemalata Thakurani — the daughter and disciple of Srinivasa Acharya, who was the trusted disciple of Gopala Bhatta himself; so Yadunandana probably heard it from Srinivasa. And the “Prema-vilasa” relates that, on leaving Ranga-kshetra, the Lord told Venkata: “I have a special mercy for this son of yours, the Vaishnava Gopala: make him learned and do not marry him” — and told Prabodhananda: “One day send him to Vrindavana.”

From childhood Gopala knew that the Lord had appeared and had taken sannyasa, and the robe of a sannyasi grieved him. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” relates that he would go off alone, weep and reproach the Creator for having given him birth in a distant land and robbing him of the joy of the pastimes in Nadia. The Lord knew his heart. Suddenly sleep overcame Gopala, and in the guise of a dream Navadvipa opened before him with all the Lord's pastimes. Waking, he saw the Lord in the form of a beautiful young householder, fell at His feet in wonder, and when he raised his eyes, a sannyasi stood before him again. The Lord comforted him, gave him an instruction that Narahari does not venture to relate, and foretold that he would soon go to Vrindavana, meet Rupa and Sanatana there, and that through his disciple their teaching would spread throughout the world.[7]

“Saying this the Lord took Gopala on His lap and drenched Gopala's body with the tears from His eyes. He said, ‘Keep all these words secret.’ Supreme bliss filled Gopala's mind.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.123–124)

So he — an eternal associate of Krishna from His Vrindavana entourage, who had appeared in a distant land to make his own special contribution to Gauranga's pastimes — received from the Lord a promise and a secret.

The four months passed.

“Thus the four months of the rainy season came to an end, and with Venkata Bhatta's consent Sri Chaitanya continued His journey through South India, visiting the temple of Sri Ranganatha before leaving. Venkata Bhatta followed the Lord a long way, unwilling to return home. Sri Chaitanya had to make great efforts to convince him that the time had come to part.” (CC, Madhya 9.164–165)

The three brothers and the boy Gopala fainted in separation; the house of the Bhattas drowned in tears. Gopala fell senseless at the Lord's feet, and the Lord, embracing him, said: “Your desire will be fulfilled: you will come to Vrindavana and there, in the company of Vaishnavas, you will constantly hear and sing the name of Krishna and worship Him. Until then, serve your father and mother at home.” Having instructed the whole family, the Lord departed.

Those words became the only medicine that kept him alive. “When will Gaurasundara take me to Vrindavana? When shall I see the Lord again?” — day and night he thought of nothing else, sinking ever deeper into love for Gaura, yet he could not leave his aged parents.

Learning

Gopala was born in a pure Vaishnava family and studied all the shastras with his paternal uncle, the great scholar Prabodhananda Sarasvati: Sanskrit grammar, poetics and rhetoric, and then all the scriptures beginning with the “Vedanta-sutra”; in the bhakti-shastras his uncle instructed him with particular care. In Nilachala he had seen Jagannatha, and in his own home the feet of Gaurasundara, the living Jagannatha, and so he became established in the position of an acharya of his own accord. Even as a boy he refuted mayavada and similar doctrines, explained and established the truth of bhakti, and was victorious everywhere in debate. Respectable people marvelled at his gifts and asked where such learning came from; some said, “By his uncle's mercy he has mastered all the shastras”, others glorified Prabodhananda himself, whose fame had spread everywhere. His Vaishnava parents rejoiced less in his learning than in his devotion. Thus Prabodhananda's pure instruction made the son of Venkata a great acharya of the Gaudiya school.

Prabodhananda was also his guru. The second verse of the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” — the book that came out under Gopala Bhatta's name — says, and the “Bhakti-ratnakara” repeats:

“Gopala Bhatta, the disciple of Prabodhananda, who is dear to the Lord, gathers [the accounts of] the delights of bhakti, pleasing Raghunatha Dasa, Rupa and Sanatana.” (“Hari-bhakti-vilasa”, 1.2; “Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.151)[8]

In Vrindavana

Gopala's parents gave their minds and lives to the feet of Sri Chaitanya. Before leaving the world, absorbed in remembrance of the Lord, they told their son: “When we are gone, go to Vrindavana and take shelter of Mahaprabhu's feet.”

“Having allowed their son to go to Vrindavana, both of them, remembering the Lord, left this world. After some time Gopala came to Vrindavana and met Rupa and Sanatana.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.164–165)

So, at the bidding of his parents and of Mahaprabhu, he went straight to Vrindavana. Prabodhananda also came to Vraja, but when is not known.[9]

“When Bhatta Gosvami came to Vrindavana, he lived with Rupa and Sanatana,” says the “Karnananda” (fifth niryasa). The brothers already knew he was coming and received him as a brother; from then on a lifelong friendship bound them. Rupa was just about to send word to Mahaprabhu in Puri with some devotees, and Rupa and Sanatana wrote to the Lord of Gopala Bhatta's arrival. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara”, the Lord in Nilachala, sitting in the house of Gadadhara Pandita, said that He had long had no news from Vraja and wished to send a letter there — and just then a letter arrived from Vrindavana. Mahaprabhu was delighted and told the devotees how He had lived four months in Venkata Bhatta's house and how his son had served Him. In His reply He wrote to Rupa and Sanatana:

“‘I am glad at Gopala's arrival. Regard Bhatta Gopala as your own brother, and send good news from time to time.’” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.189–190)

It is said that with the letter the Lord sent Gopala Bhatta tokens of His affectionate blessing — His cord-belt (dor), kaupina and outer cloth (bahirvas). Narahari Chakravarti sings that Sanatana and all who were gathered there, on receiving them, rejoiced, wept and rolled on the ground in prema, and then handed them to Gopala Bhatta, who joyfully served them as enjoined.[10] More about the meeting and the letter is told in the article on Rupa Gosvami.

In Vrindavana he lived beside Rupa and Sanatana, delighting in talks about Krishna. His nights he spent at various kundas, his days in studying the shastras and writing. Rupa loved him as his own life and entrusted him with the service of Radha-ramana. Gopala Bhatta came to Vrindavana as one of those drawn by the bhajana of Rupa and Sanatana and by the Lord's earlier command — Raghunatha Bhatta and Raghunatha Dasa came as well, while Lokanatha was living there already. According to one account, Gopala Bhatta's hut stood on the bank of the Manasa-ganga at Govardhana, and Raghunatha Dasa, who at first had no shelter at Radha-kunda, sometimes stayed with him (according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” 5.554–562, Gopala Bhatta’s dwelling was at Radha-kunda).

The “Hari-bhakti-vilasa”

In the South Gopala Bhatta had himself seen the good conduct — sadachara — of the Vaishnavas of Ramanuja's school, while there was as yet no Gaudiya code of sadachara. From Sanatana he heard that Mahaprabhu had directly ordered a Vaishnava smriti to be compiled, and he himself became eager to compile one for the benefit of future Gaudiya Vaishnavas.

“In the Bhatta's mind arose the wish to compose a Vaishnava smriti; Sanatana Gosvami knew of it at that very moment. And in Gopala's name Sri Sanatana Gosvami composed the ‘Sri Hari-bhakti-vilasa’.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.197–198)

Thus, by Mahaprabhu's wish, the code and its commentary, the “Dig-darshini”, were compiled by Sanatana himself, who out of humility hid his own name and in the opening verse named Gopala Bhatta as compiler; perhaps that verse was written by Gopala Bhatta himself, who thus began the book. According to another opinion, Sanatana compiled the book together with Gopala Bhatta, who edited it, and out of great love published it under his name. Some hold that Gopala Bhatta gave Sanatana special help in compiling the book, and that this is why Sanatana in his humility named not himself but him in it; others again recognize two books — a large “Bhagavad-bhakti-vilasa” by Gopala Bhatta and a short “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” by Sanatana: the colophon of each vilasa says, “thus in the ‘Bhagavad-bhakti-vilasa’ written by Sri Gopala Bhatta”. Many, however, consider it correct that Sanatana first compiled the book and that its present text was edited by Gopala Bhatta. So too teaches Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati: the colophon at the end of each vilasa names him as author, and Gadadhara's “Kala-sara”, Raghunandana's “Ekadashi-tattva” and other books quote it as the “Hari-bhakti”. It is also said that the book is based on notes collected by Gopala Bhatta, and that his

contribution was the editing. The “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” cites many proofs from Keshava Bhatta's “Krama-dipika”. The book is described in detail in the article on Sanatana Gosvami.

In the fifteenth vilasa (verse 39), in the karika on wearing the tapta-mudra, a “Sri Venkata Acharya-pada” is mentioned: “many wise men headed by Venkata Acharya-pada know and cite here other shrutis and smritis as well”; the commentary explains that he was the head of the Shri Vaishnava community. Whether this was Gopala Bhatta's father cannot be said: several Venkata Acharyas are known. It is also said that the Gajapati Prataparudra (1497–1540) wrote a smriti, the “Sarasvati-vilasa”, manuscripts of which survive, and some suppose that the “Bhagavad-bhakti-vilasa” and the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” are named after its model. The book was rendered into Bengali verse by Dvija Kshetranatha Tarkavagisha of the village of Rayan near Bardhaman (the manuscript was copied in 1237, probably of the Bengali era) and, briefly, by Kanai Dasa, whose complete manuscript is kept in the collection of Dhaka University.

Sanatana, in the introduction to his “Vaishnava-toshani”, names him as his helper:

“Where Gopala Bhatta and Raghunatha Dasa, nourished by a special love for Radha, give their help, every aim is achieved.” (“Vaishnava-toshani”, 13)

Together the six Gosvamis founded the “Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha”, the royal assembly of the Vaishnavas of the whole world. And the “Vaishnava-vandana” ascribed to Jiva says that Sanatana, seeking nothing for himself, compiled the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” and other books on the duties of devotees under Gopala Bhatta's name, and that Gopala Bhatta, living beside Sanatana and hearing from him about the Lord, counted himself the most fortunate of men.

The Appearance of Radha-ramana

After 1455 Shaka (1533) Gopala Bhatta set out to preach pure bhakti in the lands of present-day Uttar Pradesh. Near Haridvar, by the village of Deoband (Devaband) in the district of Saharanpur, where a family of learned Gauda brahmanas lived, a storm with heavy rain overtook him. The villagers welcomed him joyfully, and one brahmana, a devotee of Krishna, received him in his house. The brahmana had no children; Gopala Bhatta, learning his desire, blessed him: “May you have a son who will be a great devotee of Krishna.” The brahmana humbly served his guest and promised to give him his firstborn as a servant and disciple, for the service of Krishna. For several days Gopala Bhatta preached the name of Hari there.

On the way back he took twelve shalagrama-shilas from the river Gandaki — the Lord Himself, manifest in the sacred shilas of the Gandaki — and carried them in a cloth bag on his neck, serving them as Vrajendra-nandana Himself.[11] One day, returning from his bath in the Yamuna, he saw a boy at his hut. “I am from Deoband in Saharanpur,” the boy said. “My father has sent me to serve you. My name is Gopinatha.” It was the son of that brahmana, and from then on he served Gopala Bhatta with great devotion.[12]

Gopala Bhatta longed to serve the Lord in a Deity form, so that his service might be fuller. Once some wealthy merchants brought clothes and ornaments to his hut. All night he wondered: how would the shalagrama wear these clothes and ornaments, made for Krishna's body? He offered them to the shilas, performed arati, offered bhoga and laid the shilas to rest in their basket. In the morning, after bathing in the Yamuna, he opened the basket and saw that one of the twelve shalagramas had revealed Himself as the sweet, dark young cowherd of Vraja — two-armed, holding the flute, standing in the threefold bend. The Lord had fulfilled His devotee's desire. Gopala Bhatta, as if in an ocean of joy, bowed before Him and began to offer hymns.

Overjoyed, he called Rupa, Sanatana and the other Gosvamis. Hearing that Krishna had appeared to him, they came at once with the devotees and, seeing the Deity, were filled with prema and tears of love. On the vaishakha-purnima of 1599 Samvat (1542) Gopala Bhatta held a great festival of abhisheka, and the Gosvamis named the Deity “Sri Radha-ramana”.[13] Since then the festival of His appearance, when the Deity is bathed before all, is celebrated every year on the full moon of Vaishakha. Radha-ramana stands alone, without Radha: on His left, in Her place, is a silver crown, the sign of Radharani. His temple is among the foremost in Vrindavana.

Radha-ramana also granted him the sight of Gauranga Himself. Remembering how in his own home, at his father's command, he had served Gaurachand, Gopala Bhatta could not keep his composure, was bathed in tears and looked again and again at Radha-ramana — and then “Sri Radha-ramana, subdued by Gopala's love, at that very moment took the form of Sri Gaurasundara” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 4.343–345).

The “Seva-prakatya” likewise dates the appearance of Radha-ramana to 1599 Vikrama — twelve years after the departure of Vallabha. The Vallabhite “Chaurasi Baithak” invents the story that Vallabha revealed the Deity and that Gopala Bhatta in his next life became a Pushtimargi named “Gopala Naga”; this is a fabrication, and Vaishnavas reject it: Vallabha's own son Vitthalanatha arranged in Mathura the worship of Gopala Bhatta together with Rupa. The lands for Radha-ramana's service Gopala Bhatta obtained in exchange for one maund of wheat and one bullock; they are what is called the “Ghera”, the enclosure.

Gopinatha Pujari and the Servants of Radha-ramana

When Gopinatha of Deoband grew up, Gopala Bhatta gave him diksha and entrusted him with the service of Radha-ramana. He remained a brahmachari, served Radha-ramana to the end of his life and became known as Gopinatha Pujari Gosvami. He was a Gauda brahmana of the Shandilya gotra. His younger brother Damodara Dasa also came from Deoband to Vrindavana, received the mantra and mercy from Gopinatha, and likewise served Radha-ramana; he lived in Vrindavana with his wife and had three sons — Harinatha, Mathuranatha and Harirama. Today the service of Radha-ramana is in the hands of their descendants.[14]

Among the Gosvamis

When the Deity Gopala (Shrinathji) stayed for a month in Mathura with Vitthalanatha (Vitthaleshvara), Rupa came there with his closest companions to see and serve Him, and in that list of companions Gopala Bhatta is named first:

“He was accompanied by Gopala Bhatta Gosvami, Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami, Raghunatha Bhatta Gosvami and Lokanatha Dasa Gosvami.” (CC, Madhya 18.49)

The other Gosvamis remembered him with love. Jiva, at the beginning of the “Shat-sandarbha”, calls him “Bhatta-pada, the friend of Rupa and Sanatana, born in a family of southern brahmanas”, and in the introduction to the “Gopala-champu” invokes: “O Krishna, Krishna Chaitanya, Rupa, Sanatana, Gopala Bhatta Prabhu…” Raghunatha Dasa, in the closing verse of the “Manah-shiksha”, promises that whoever sings these verses, following Rupa together with his group — Sanatana, Gopala Bhatta, Raghunatha Bhatta, Jiva — will attain the treasure of bhajana. And the “Bhakti-ratnakara”, listing the mahantas gathered to see Srinivasa off, says: “Gosvami Gopala Bhatta is most merciful; Bhugarbha and Sri Lokanatha are an abode of virtues” (6.510).[15]

Gopala Bhatta's Verse and Songs

Rupa Gosvami, in the “Padyavali” (verse 38), quotes a kirtana-verse of names ascribed to Gopala Bhatta:

“O lord of Bhandiravana, adorned with a peacock feather, best of all, anointed with sandal, lord of Vrindavana, dark as a blue lotus, darling of the Kalindi, son of Nanda, highest bliss, lotus-eyed Govinda, Mukunda of beautiful form — gladden me, wretched as I am!” (“Padyavali”, 38)

According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (6.401–402), overwhelmed by separation, he would sit in solitude, his eyes and mind given to Radha-ramana, and sing this verse; and who, hearing these names, could keep his composure? Several songs in Brajabhasha on the pastimes of Radha-Govinda — on life in the bowers of Vrindavana, on the swing, on a lovers' quarrel — bearing Gopala Bhatta's signature (bhanita) also circulate as his; but whether they are genuine is hard to say.

Writings

The kadacha and the “Shat-sandarbha”. From the lips of Rupa and Sanatana Gopala Bhatta heard how Sri Krishna Chaitanya had analysed sambandha, abhidheya and prayojana — and he set this down in a “kadacha”, a collection of aphoristic verses (karikas) on Gaudiya Vaishnava philosophy. From that kadacha Jiva compiled the “Shat-sandarbha” (the “Bhagavata-sandarbha”). At the beginning of each sandarbha Jiva writes that the southern Bhatta wrote this book to please the saintly Rupa and Sanatana, and that Jiva, having examined his first draft — in places orderly, in places disordered or broken off — sets everything out in order. The fourth verse of the introduction to the “Tattva-sandarbha” says that a certain Bhatta, their friend, of a family of southern brahmanas, wrote a book after examining the books of the ancient Vaishnavas; Baladeva Vidyabhushana explains: “their” means Rupa's and Sanatana's, the “friend” is Gopala Bhatta, the “ancient Vaishnavas” are Madhva and others. Thus Gopala Bhatta is the compiler of a concise “Bhagavata-sandarbha”, and his kadacha is the source of the “Shat-sandarbha”: he laid the foundation of the six theses that Jiva developed.[16] More on this is told in the article on Jiva Gosvami.

The “Sat-kriya-sara-dipika”. This is a Vedic paddhati — a manual of marriage and the other samskaras — in Sanskrit, in prose and verse. Gopala Bhatta compiled it at the bidding of devotees of pure Krishna-bhakti — for brahmana householders and others who worship Govinda exclusively, and for devotees born of mixed varnas — so as to protect their bhakti in every respect. The “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” says much about the duties of wealthy Vaishnava householders, but not about marriage and the other samskaras, while the existing paddhatis — those of Aniruddha Bhatta, Bhima Bhatta, Govinda Bhatta, Narayana Bhatta (for followers of the great rites) and Bhavadeva Bhatta (for Samavedins) — were written for people of karma. This book is for the devotees of Govinda, both within varnashrama and among the antyajas. Drawing on the Vedas, the Puranas, Manu and other smritis and examining the offences in service and against the holy name, it excludes the worship of the pitris and of other gods: shraddha and the cult of gods other than Vishnu are not enjoined for those wholly surrendered to Govinda and would be an offence for them. By serving Krishna they honour the pitris and the gods incidentally, and the kirtana of Hari's name makes up for all worship. (The ninth vilasa of the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” likewise allows shraddha and the honouring of the gods only with the remnants of Vishnu's food, and forbids worshipping them independently.)

The book covers the duties of a householder and the meaning of renunciation, the rites before marriage and the prohibition of the smarta nandimukha-shraddha, the maha-vyahriti-homa, marriage and the rites that follow, garbhadhana, pumsavana, simantonnayana, jata-karma, nishkramana, name-giving, the first feeding, chudakarana, upanayana, brahmacharya, samavartana and more. In the introduction the author writes that he writes “at the bidding of the sadhus”, although it would not befit him to call himself the author, for fear of the fault of one who, “bewildered by false ego”, thinks himself the doer (Gita, 3.27);

and in his own commentary he explains that “Sriman Gopala Bhatta” is a certain soul who always drinks the honey of Sri Krishna Chaitanya's feet and obeys the instructions of the sadhus.

Part of the “Sat-kriya-sara-dipika” is the “Samskara-dipika”: on Vaishnavas of the sampradaya and tantric ones, on householders and sannyasis, on the ten-named sannyasa and the glory of paramahamsas and avadhutas, on attaining brahminhood through Vaishnava diksha, on the ashramas of women, on Vaishnava sannyasa for the wholly surrendered, even those born shudras, on the rites of sannyasa, the Hari-mandira tilaka, the nama-mudra, prana-pratishtha, acceptance of the achyuta-gotra, worship of the shalagrama, and the samadhi-mantra — the rites at the departure of a Vaishnava sannyasi. The closing verse of the printed edition says that the “Samskara-dipika”, accepted by the saints for the sake of sannyasa, was made for the exclusive dharma of Gaura's servants, and the colophon names Sri Gopala Bhatta Gosvami as compiler. The book also cites Advaita, Sri Krishna Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, Gadadhara, Nityananda, Srivasa, Haridasa, Raghunatha Dasa, Madhva, Ramanuja, Shankara and the author of the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa”.

Two manuscripts of these books were described by Hara Prasad Shastri in the “Notices of Sanskrit Manuscripts”. Bhaktivinoda Thakura copied their old manuscripts from Vrindavana in his own hand and was the first to print both books, in the “Sajjana-toshani” (vols. 15–17, 1903–1909). Another manuscript of the “Samskara-dipika”, in Bengali script and fragile in places, was obtained in Sanketa in Vraja, at Gopala Bhatta's place of bhajana, from a very old Vrajavasi. Unlike the printed edition, it has an introduction and many new verses. The introduction bows to Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda and says: by the instruction of Sri Krishna Chaitanya — Rupa and Sanatana; and at the bidding of them, of Sri Jiva, of Raghunatha and of Raghunatha called Bhatta, Sri Gopala Bhatta Gosvami diligently compiled the “Sat-kriya-sara-dipika”, having examined the views of Ramanuja and others and out of kindness to the noble in the Madhva sampradaya, while the “Samskara-dipika” included in it was composed by “Gopi-bhritya”, “the servant of the gopis”.[17] In the list of the guru-parampara the manuscript also has a shloka absent from the printed edition: “Sanatana and Rupa, Bhatta Raghunatha, the one called Bhatta Gopala, Jiva and Raghunatha”; whether it belongs to the author or to a copyist is unclear. After the colophon the manuscript describes the seats and holy places of the four sampradayas, with obeisances to Ramanujacharya and Madhvacharya. According to the description of the manuscript, Gopala Bhatta, one of the six Gosvamis, compiled the “Sat-kriya-sara-dipika” at the wish of Rupa, Sanatana and the other Gosvamis.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati performed the last rites of Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji according to Gopala Bhatta's “Samskara-dipika” and established his samadhi, and publishing the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa”, the “Sat-kriya-sara-dipika” and the “Samskara-dipika” was part of his plan to restore the Vaishnava smriti to use.

A commentary on the “Krishna-karnamrita”. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” says:

“He wrote a commentary on the ‘Krishna-karnamrita’, hearing which the Vaishnavas feel supreme bliss.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.228)

The “Anuraga-valli” also speaks of this commentary on Bilvamangala's poem; Gopala Bhatta is said to have written many other books as well.[18]

Disciples

Only three of his disciples are especially well known, and some say he accepted only three. Two became famous for their service: Srinivasa Acharya in Gauda and Gopinatha Pujari in Vrindavana; the third, Harivamsha, is known “by contrast”: his guru rejected him.

Srinivasa came to Vraja when Rupa, Sanatana, Kashishvara and Raghunatha Bhatta had already withdrawn from sight, while Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta and Jiva were still on earth. According to the “Nava-padya”, the departed Gosvamis told him in a dream: “This is no time for grief: Gopala Bhatta is here; receive from him the supreme Gopala-mantra and our books, and go to Gauda.” Jiva took Srinivasa to Gopala Bhatta and to Radha-ramana and introduced him to Lokanatha, Bhugarbha, Paramananda and Madhu Pandita; Gopala Bhatta was glad to see him, and Srinivasa humbly asked for initiation. At Gopala Bhatta's direction Jiva bathed Srinivasa in the Yamuna and brought him back, and the next morning in the Radha-ramana temple Gopala Bhatta gave him the diksha mantra and, seeing his thirst and sincerity, blessed him: “May every perfection be yours.”[19] Thus Srinivasa, the companion of Narottama, by Jiva's mercy became the diksha-disciple of Gopala Bhatta and the shiksha-disciple of Jiva.

“After some time Srinivasa came to him there, and the Bhatta mercifully fulfilled his hope. Having become his disciple, Srinivasa, by the Lord's command, came to Gauda and revealed there the books of bhakti.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.230–231)

At Gopala Bhatta's wish Jiva sent Srinivasa to Gauda to spread the books of the Gosvamis; before leaving, Srinivasa received the order and blessing of Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha, Lokanatha, Madhu Pandita and others — each of them blessed the three envoys carrying the books. Srinivasa belonged to Rupa's own group: Gopala Bhatta heard Gaurasundara's teaching from the lips of Rupa and Sanatana and created a “casket of jewels” of Gaudiya philosophy and smriti, while Srinivasa, who took shelter at his feet, the shiksha-disciple of Jiva and friend of Narottama, showed himself by conduct and preaching to be the best of Rupanugas. More on this is told in the articles on Jiva Gosvami and Srinivasa Acharya.

When Srinivasa came to Vrindavana a second time — after the departure of Shuklambara, Gadadhara Dasa, Narahari and Dvija Haridasa — Gopala Bhatta, Jiva, Bhugarbha and Lokanatha encouraged him, and he heard from them accounts of Gaura and Krishna. Srinivasa's disciple Ramachandra Kaviraja also received in Vrindavana the blessing of Gopala Bhatta, Lokanatha and Bhugarbha.[20] Narottama was the darling of the three Gosvamis still living — Gopala Bhatta, Jiva and Raghunatha Dasa — and Jiva taught Shyamananda from his own books and those of Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta and others.

When Jahnava came to Vraja, Gopala Bhatta was still alive: the leaders of the Vaishnavas — Jiva, Gopala Bhatta, Lokanatha, Bhugarbha, Madhu Pandita — came to honour her, and among those who met her in Mathura was “Gopala Bhatta Gosvami, a treasury of Gaura-prema”.

The third disciple, Harivamsha, a Gauda brahmana of the Kashyapa gotra, Gopala Bhatta rejected for some reason. Various stories are told about him; their gist is that Gopala Bhatta rejected him for breaking the rules of conduct. It is said that the name of the guru, Gopala Bhatta, was later maliciously inserted into the list of Harivamsha's own disciples. Banamali Lal Gosvami says that his family is related by marriage to the descendants of Harivamsha.

Why the Early Books Are Silent About Him

Some wonder: Kaviraja in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” merely named Gopala Bhatta among his six shiksha-gurus and told nothing about him; Vrindavana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” does not mention him at all; the “Chaitanya-charita-mahakavya” and the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka” describe the four months in the house of Trimalla Bhatta but name neither Venkata nor his son; and the Sanskrit “Sri Krishna-chaitanya-charitamrita” ascribed to Murari Gupta speaks only of Trimalla and calls the boy Gopala his son:

“When the Lord of the world was seated at His ease, the best of brahmanas named Trimalla, overflowing with love, served Him together with his wife, his sons and all his kinsfolk. His little boy named Gopala was then standing at the Lord's side. Seeing him, the Lord, His heart melting with compassion, placed His lotus foot on the boy's head and said, ‘Say “Hari”!’ And the boy, filled with joy, gave up his childish games and began to sing of Krishna and to dance.” (Murari Gupta, “Sri Krishna-chaitanya-charitamrita”, 3.15.14–16)

The “Chaitanya-charitamrita”, too, names the Lord's host as Trimalla in one place and Venkata in another, without stating their relationship or naming Gopala:

“During the rainy season the Lord spent four months as the guest of the brahmana Trimalla Bhatta.” (CC, Madhya 1.108)

This rather shows that the house was one and the brothers lived together: the Kaviraja recalled one brother in one place and the other in another (CC, Madhya 1.108–110; 9.82–165). The “Prema-vilasa” of Nityananda Dasa mentions Gopala Bhatta without naming either Venkata or Trimalla as his father; the later “Anuraga-valli” of Manohara Dasa, following the “Bhakti-ratnakara”, calls Trimalla the eldest brother, Venkata the middle and Prabodhananda the youngest, and Gopala the son of Venkata. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” itself says this not on its own authority but on that of an ancient verse (1.98); the “Vartika-prakasha” on Nabhaji's “Bhakta-mala” also calls him Venkata's son. Murari's printed kadacha exists in only one edition, whereas disputed questions call for several manuscripts and variant readings; besides, it does not mention Prabodhananda either.

Narahari Chakravarti reveals the reason for the silence. Before writing the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”, the Kaviraja asked Gopala Bhatta's permission:

“Sri Gopala Bhatta gladly gave his permission, but forbade him to describe in the book anything concerning himself. Why he forbade it — who can understand? He always considered himself the lowest of the low. The Kaviraja could not transgress his order: he writes only his name and makes nothing else known.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.222–224)

The order of the guru is carried out without deliberation — and that is why the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” does not say whose son he was. Prabodhananda, through Gopala Bhatta, likewise asked that his deeds not be described in it. It is the nature of pure Vaishnavas not to report, as worldly historians do, about the parents of their gurus; even when the parents are Vaishnavas, disciples keep silent about them at the guru's bidding, and worldly historians cannot understand this; there are exceptions, but they are not the rule. The intimate, renounced associates of Gaura — Prabodhananda, Gopala Bhatta and others — out of great humility themselves forbade others to write about them: that is why the early books are silent.

Some invent other reasons. It is said that Vrindavana Dasa, an opponent of the “Gaura-nagari” doctrine, did not name Prabodhananda — because of the words “gaura-nagara-vara” in his “Chaitanya-chandramrita” (132) — nor his shiksha-disciple Gopala Bhatta; the “Vishnupriya-patrika” even wrote that Prabodhananda had sheltered Harivamsha, whom Gopala Bhatta had rejected, and that this is why the biographers are silent about him. But none of Gaura's associates accepted such fabrications. The late “Advaita-prakasha” (ch. 17) and Lal Dasa's “Bhakta-mala” identify Prabodhananda with the mayavadi Prakashananda; this was refuted in the “Sajjana-toshani” (year 18, no. 5) and in Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's article “Sri Prabodhananda”. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta calls Prabodhananda the guru and uncle of Gopala Bhatta, an eternal associate of the Lord, and to call him a mayavadi is an offence.

Some recent writers claim that Gopala Bhatta's ancestral village was “Bhattamari” in the South. But in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” the bhattathari (their “bhattamari”) are a gang of false ascetics, not a place:

“Then He came to Amlitala, where He saw the Deity of Sri Rama, and then went on to Mallara-desha, where the nomadic bhattathari lived.” (CC, Madhya 9.224; cf. 1.112; 9.226–233)

Narahari warns:

“Of these events of Sri Gopala Bhatta's life some tell a little, and others tell nothing at all. Whoever, not grasping the essence, raises false arguments about this, in his heart the seed of offence sprouts.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.209–210)

The seeming disagreements of Vaishnava books mislead worldly historians and the “burden-bearers” — those who carry the load of words without grasping their essence; and it was so that the “essence-takers” should not be confused that Narahari warned his readers.

Last Years and Departure

After the departure of Rupa and Sanatana Gopala Bhatta remained in Vrindavana and, in unceasing separation, sang and recalled their virtues. His mind given to the feet of Radha-ramana, he would sometimes recite his verses, sometimes lose his composure while chanting the names, sometimes, repeating “Hare Krishna”, be bathed in tears, his voice breaking.

He departed in Vrindavana on the krishna-panchami of the month of Shridhara — so by our calendar.[21] His samadhi is behind the present temple of Radha-ramana. Narottama Dasa cries out in a song of lament: “Where are Raghunatha Bhatta and Gopala Bhatta?” And the glory of the six Gosvamis, it is said, is best understood through Srinivasa Acharya's “Shad-gosvamy-ashtaka”.

Songs About Him

The “Stava-panchaka” — five verses on his greatness ascribed to Krishnadasa Kaviraja — is quoted by Yadunandana Dasa in the “Karnananda” (fifth niryasa) and rendered into Bengali verse. His power is to proclaim bhakti for Hari without cease; his realization is always true, and he is detached from all that perishes; the place where he lived became famous through the coming of Mahaprabhu, Who lived joyfully in his house. In Vraja he is Guna-manjari, and he appeared out of compassion for the people of Kali to distribute the sweetness of madhura-rasa. Tears, perspiration, gooseflesh, trembling, a breaking voice at the name, fainting at the syllables “ha-ha-ha Hari”; intoxicated with the taste of his Vraja mood, he dances, laughs, sings and wanders like a madman, while outwardly acting on the command to deliver the people of Kali. He knows all the subtleties of rati and rasa, and whoever reads this hymn enters the circle of the manjaris. The Bengali rendering echoes the Kaviraja: “Sri Gopala Bhatta is a most excellent branch; he spoke of prema with Rupa and Sanatana.”

Manohara Dasa's song begins with longing for his feet: his body is made of love, golden, his face a moon; Rupa and Sanatana are dearer to him than life, the two Raghunathas are his life; with Pandita Krishna and Lokanatha he is one soul in different bodies; Radha-ramana is his all; he is a bee at Chaitanya's feet and is won over by mercy to Srinivasa; together with all he relishes rasa, mad with bhava — such is his eternal occupation; he is an ocean of raga and a friend of the lowly. Who this Manohara was is unclear: Rupa in the “Padyavali” (274–275) quotes two verses of a certain Manohara, the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Adi 11.46, 52) mentions a Manohara, and yet another Manohara Dasa is named among those at the festival in Kheturi. Radhavallabha's song about Raghunatha Bhatta also remembers him: “Sri Rupa and Sanatana, honoured by all, Sri Gopala, Bhatta-Raghunatha…”

Narahari Chakravarti composed a song about his whole life: the son of Venkata Bhatta, the crown of the brahmana line, the beloved yati of Gaura, a wondrous image of bhajana; even as a child he was full of bhakti and intoxicated with Krishna-rasa. The Lord lived four months with Trimalla and Venkata, and the boy served Him at his father's bidding; the Lord gave him the nectar of prema, revealed His own

truth and, taking his hand, said: “I am subject to your prema; soon you will go to Vraja and find Rupa and Sanatana there.” Gopala wept at His feet, and the Lord took him on His lap and bathed him in tears and, on leaving, comforted Venkata and Trimalla again and again. A few days later Gopala left home, came to Vraja and met Rupa, Sanatana and Lokanatha; from Nilachala came the dor and bahirvas. Day and night he sang of Gauranga, was always in Rupa's assembly, inseparable from Sanatana; Radha-ramana appeared from the shalagrama to show Who is subject to his prema. He lived in Vrindavana and visited Radha-kunda, Govardhana, Varshana, Nandishvara, Yavata — where he saw the former dwelling and drowned in bliss — Gokula-Mahavana in solitude, and Lokanatha; he loved the Vrajavasis and joyfully gave bhakti — “the guru of Srinivasa Acharya”.

And the ancient verse quoted by the “Bhakti-ratnakara”:

“I bow to Gopala Bhatta, whose heart is flooded with love for Sanatana, who is distinguished in all things by his friendship with Sri Rupa, whose only life is Radha-ramana, who grants their desires to those who worship.” (“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 1.208)

Bhaktivinoda Thakura writes that on Gopala Bhatta lay the care that no one should distort the pure shringara-rasa or show groundless disregard for vaidhi-bhakti (“Jaiva-dharma”, ch. 39); together with Rupa and others he restored the lost holy places of Vrindavana and composed many books, among them a bhakti-smriti (“Sajjana-toshani”, 2.7).

Ananga-manjari

Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” reveals who Gopala Bhatta was in Krishna's pastimes:

“Ananga-manjari is now Gopala Bhatta; but some call Bhatta Gosvami Sri Guna-manjari.” (GGD 184)[22]

In the drama “Chaitanya-chandrodaya” Karnapura names neither Gopala Bhatta nor Jiva, but in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” he names both and speaks of their position in Vraja. The “Stava-panchaka”, too, calls him Guna-manjari, and the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (4.339) “Guna- or Ananga-manjari”.

Let us then bow to the dust of the feet of Gopala Bhatta, whose life is Radha-ramana and who is the friend of Rupa and Sanatana, and pray that we may not be deceived by the judgements of the “burden-bearers” but accept the judgement of the “essence-takers”, which is directed to the service of the Vaishnavas.

1. According to the “Sri Radharamana-prakatya” (in Hindi) by Pandita Madhusudana Gosvami Sarvabhauma of the Radha-ramana enclosure in Vrindavana, he appeared in 1557 Samvat (1500), received the Lord's mercy in Ranga-kshetra at eleven, in 1568 Samvat (1511), came to Vraja in 1588 Samvat (1531), and departed in 1642 Samvat (1585), at eighty-five. One of the biographies dates his life the same way (noting that according to some he appeared in 1503), placing his departure in 1507 Shaka.

2. According to one of the biographies, the krishna-trayodashi of the month of pausha.

3. Venkata is named as Gopala's father by the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (on the strength of an ancient verse, 1.98), the “Anuraga-valli” and the “Vartika-prakasha” on the “Bhakta-mala”; according to the Sanskrit “Sri Krishna-chaitanya-charitamrita” ascribed to Murari Gupta, he is Trimalla's son. See below, “Why the Early Books Are Silent About Him”.

4. In one of the biographies the youngest brother is called “Gopala Guru, later Prabodhananda”; he should not be confused with Gopala Guru Gosvami of Puri.

5. According to one of the biographies, in 1510.

6. According to one account, the Lord noticed in Venkata a pride in the object of his worship — Narayana, the source of all avataras, the “unborn” — and, as Madhusudana who crushes pride, resolved to remove it; finding no answer, Venkata was saddened. The Lord explained that in Narayana two and a half of the five principal rasas are manifest, and in Krishna all twelve; Krishna, appearing to the gopis in the form of Narayana, could not keep His four-armed form before Radha

(“Bhakti-ratnakara”, 5.624–629). According to another, before this conversation Venkata held Narayana to be supreme, and the Lord corrected his view in jest, so that Venkata, raised in Ramanuja's school, turned to Gaudiya Vaishnavism. Venkata is an eternal associate of the Lord, and this “pride” is part of the pastime by which the Lord revealed Krishna's supremacy to the world.

7. One of the biographies, retelling the “Bhakti-ratnakara”, places this vision before the meeting with the Lord; by the text of the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (1.99–124) it took place when the Lord was already living in Venkata's house.

8. By this verse Prabodhananda is his diksha-guru, and some biographies take it so. Others call Prabodhananda his teacher of the shastras and Gopala his shiksha-disciple.

9. According to one of the biographies, when the Lord stayed in Shrirangam Gopala was five years old (cf. note 1); a few years after the Lord's return to Puri Prabodhananda left Shrirangam and settled in Kamyavana, in the district of Mathura, while in Gopala Bhatta a burning desire to live in Vraja gradually arose, and he followed the path of his uncle and guru.

10. So according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (1.194) and one of the biographies; Narahari's song names the cord-belt and the outer cloth. According to another biography, the Lord sent Rupa by messenger a kaupina and the outer garments of a babaji as tokens of renunciation; Rupa received them with great joy, and Gopala Bhatta accepted them as the Lord's mercy and prasada. According to a third, the Lord out of love sent him His own belt, kaupina and the wooden seat He used to sit on; these are honoured to this day by the servants of the Radha-ramana temple.

11. According to one of the biographies, he found a single shalagrama-shila on the bank of the Gandaki and carried it with him everywhere; in another of its accounts, he worshipped twelve.

12. So according to one biography: the boy came before the Deity appeared. According to another, he came after the appearance, almost ten years after the blessing given to his father.

13. According to some reports, Sri Radha-Govinda revealed Gopala Bhatta's desire to Rupa in a dream, and Rupa himself manifested the Deity of Radha-ramana; the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (1.199–200) also says that Govinda gave Rupa a command in a dream and that Rupa entrusted Gopala Bhatta with the service of Radha-ramana. One of the biographies gives the year of the appearance as “1599 of the Christian era”; it is 1599 Samvat.

14. According to another report, the service of Radha-ramana is today in the line of Gopinatha Pujari himself. In one of the biographies Damodara's third son is called Harinama (probably a misprint).

15. The number follows our Bengali edition; one of the biographies gives this verse as 6.310 (which is about Radha-Damodara).

16. According to other accounts, Gopala Bhatta's contribution was the preparation of notes on which Jiva relied, or even a preface to the “Shat-sandarbha”.

17. Whether this was the name of the author of the “Samskara-dipika”, an epithet of Gopala Bhatta or his hidden name remains unclear: the first and last verses of the “Samskara-dipika” are signed “Gopi-bhrita” or “Gopi-bhritya”.

18. According to one of the biographies, the commentary on the “Krishna-karnamrita” known under his name, the “Krishna-vallabha”, is not his: it has no obeisance to Sri Krishna Chaitanya, and the author calls himself a brahmana of Dravida, son of Harivamsha Bhatta and grandson of Nrisimha Bhatta; there are no such colophons in the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” or other books of the Gosvamis. The commentary quotes the “Bhagavatam”, Shridhara, the “Gita-govinda”, the “Ujjvala-nilamani”, the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu”, the “Padyavali” and the “Jagannatha-vallabha”; the Kaviraja, who himself wrote on the “Karnamrita” (the “Saranga-rangada”), does not name it, and the “Bhakti-ratnakara” neither mentions nor quotes the “Krishna-vallabha”. To the same son of Harivamsha Bhatta belong the “Rasika-ranjani” on Bhanudatta's “Rasa-manjari”, the smriti “Samaya-kaumudi” (“Kala-kaumudi”) on the times for rites, diksha, Janmashtami and the installation of Deities, and the incomplete “Rasa-tarangini” on Rudra's “Shringara-tilaka”: had he been one of the Gosvamis, the Kaviraja would have named at least one of these books; Aufrecht's catalogue lists several Gopala Bhattas. In the library of Madhusudana Gosvami Sarvabhauma in the Radha-ramana Ghera there is also a manuscript of a commentary “Krishna-vallabha” on the “Gopala-tapani-shruti” with a colophon of Prabodhananda Sarasvati, written “by the power of Sri Krishna Chaitanya”. And the Bhandarkar Institute in Pune holds a manuscript of yet another commentary on the “Krishna-karnamrita”, the “Shravanahladini”: its author calls himself “Gopala Bhatta, whose mind is attached to the feet of Radha-ramana”, and at first he seems to be Gopala Bhatta Gosvami; but his guru is “Narayana”, his father “Bhaddanphana (?)”, he wrote for his friend Banamali Dasa and his younger brother Lakshmi-Narayana, following the Bengali text of the “Karnamrita”, and he quotes the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” — that is, he wrote after it.

19. According to one account, the next day Gopala Bhatta himself sent Srinivasa to Raghunatha Dasa at Radha-kunda; according to another, Srinivasa went there together with Jiva.

20. According to one of the biographies, these Gosvamis gave him the title “Kaviraja”; according to another, Jiva did.

21. According to one of the biographies, the krishna-shashthi (the month is not named). On the year of his departure see note 1.

22. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (66) also applies the same name to Radha's younger sister, who is now Jahnava (or Vasudha); Karnapura does not explain this.